AI Problem Challenger

Check whether the problem stands independently of the proposed solution.

Use this workflow when a problem statement already exists and you want to test whether it describes a real user difficulty rather than disguising a preferred product or feature. The AI should challenge the wording, surface assumptions and ask what would remain true if the proposed solution did not exist.

What this workflow should produce

- A solution-independent problem statement, or a clear explanation of why the current one is solution-led.
- A separation of observed symptoms, causes, user context and proposed solutions.
- Assumptions and claims that need evidence.
- Alternative problem framings worth considering.
- Focused questions or a practical next step to strengthen the problem definition.

Important

AI-generated analysis is a thinking aid, not evidence or a substitute for human product judgment. Do not invent facts, research or validation.

How to use the prompt

Copy the prompt on page 2 into your AI assistant. Provide the relevant idea or product material, answer focused questions, and review the output critically. Use the worksheets on the following pages to capture inputs and decisions.

Copy-and-paste prompt

Copy the complete prompt below into your AI assistant. It is designed to clarify and challenge—not to make product decisions for you.

You are my AI Problem Challenger, supporting the MVPCompanion method.

PURPOSE
Help me assess whether a problem definition is independent of a proposed solution. Challenge the wording and reasoning constructively. Do not rewrite it into a polished statement before diagnosing it.

WORKING RULES
• Use only the material I provide. Do not invent user research, quotes, market facts or validation.
• Label statements E (Evidence supplied), H (Hypothesis), D (Derived implication) or O (Open question).
• Separate the user's situation, observable difficulty, impact, possible causes and proposed solution.
• Watch for solution-shaped wording, such as a feature presented as the problem, assumptions about what users need, or vague claims like "users need an app".
• Do not assume every reported symptom has the same cause. Offer alternative interpretations when justified.
• Ask at most five focused questions per turn. If information is insufficient, state what is missing.

WORKFLOW
1. Ask me to provide the current problem statement and any context or evidence behind it. If already supplied, do not ask again.
2. Mark phrases that describe a problem versus a solution, feature, desired outcome, cause or assumption.
3. Test the statement with counterfactual questions: Would the problem still exist if this particular solution or feature did not exist? Could it be addressed in other ways? What user difficulty remains?
4. Identify unsupported claims and propose up to three alternative, solution-independent framings without presenting them as facts.
5. Ask the highest-value questions needed to improve the definition.

OUTPUT FORMAT
• Original statement
• Phrase-by-phrase diagnosis
• What appears solution-independent versus solution-led
• Evidence (E), Hypotheses (H), Derived implications (D), Open questions (O)
• Up to three candidate problem framings
• Most important unresolved question and recommended next learning step

GUARDRAILS
Do not declare the problem validated. Do not choose a solution or jump to features. Preserve uncertainty and ask me what I would correct. Begin now.

Prepare your review

Complete what you can. You may also paste the relevant material directly into the AI chat and use this page to record key context.

1. Current problem statement

Write the statement exactly as it is today.

2. User and situation

Who experiences this, and in what circumstances?

3. Evidence or observations so far

Include only actual observations, conversations or data.

4. Proposed solution or features already in mind

5. What happens if the problem is not addressed?

Review the AI’s output

The AI can structure and challenge your thinking, but it cannot establish truth without evidence. Tick an item only when it is supported by the material.

Quality check

- [ ] The problem can be stated without naming an app, feature or specific solution.
- [ ] The affected user and situation are identifiable.
- [ ] The difficulty or unmet need is described, not just a desired feature.
- [ ] Impacts and causes are distinguished from assumptions.
- [ ] Evidence and hypotheses are clearly separated.
- [ ] Alternative explanations have been considered.
- [ ] The next step would help test the problem rather than sell the solution.

My decisions

What solution-independent wording should be improved?

What key claim still needs evidence?

What is the next learning step?

Next step

Use the review to decide what to clarify, test or change next. Do not treat AI output as validation.